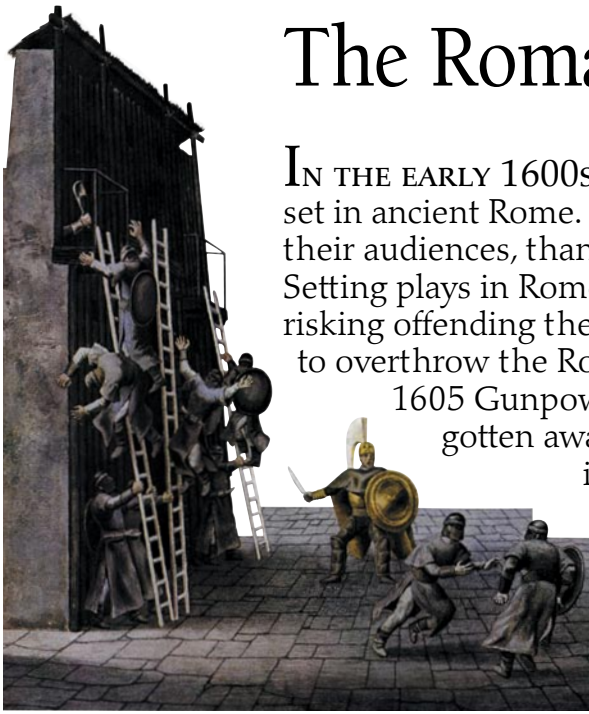


The Roman plays

IN THE EARLY 1600s, both Shakespeare and Ben Jonson wrote tragedies set in ancient Rome. This subject was familiar to educated members of their audiences, thanks to the influence of Roman writers like Seneca. Setting plays in Rome allowed playwrights to raise political issues without risking offending the government. Ben Jonson's *Catiline* deals with a plot to overthrow the Roman state, but the real subject of the play was the 1605 Gunpowder Plot to kill King James. Jonson could not have gotten away with writing about this directly, so he set his play in the distant world of ancient Rome.



Poster for a 1965 production of *Coriolanus*

ROMAN REJECT

In his play *Coriolanus*, Shakespeare tells the story of an ambitious Roman nobleman called Coriolanus, who is a great warrior but a poor politician. He despises the ordinary people of Rome, but needs their support in order to be made consul, or head of state. When the people reject Coriolanus, he abandons Rome and joins the city's enemies, the Volscians.

In the play Julius Caesar, the ghost of the murdered leader returns to speak to Brutus, the man who killed him



Brutus, who plans Caesar's murder



Mark Antony, who defeats Brutus in war

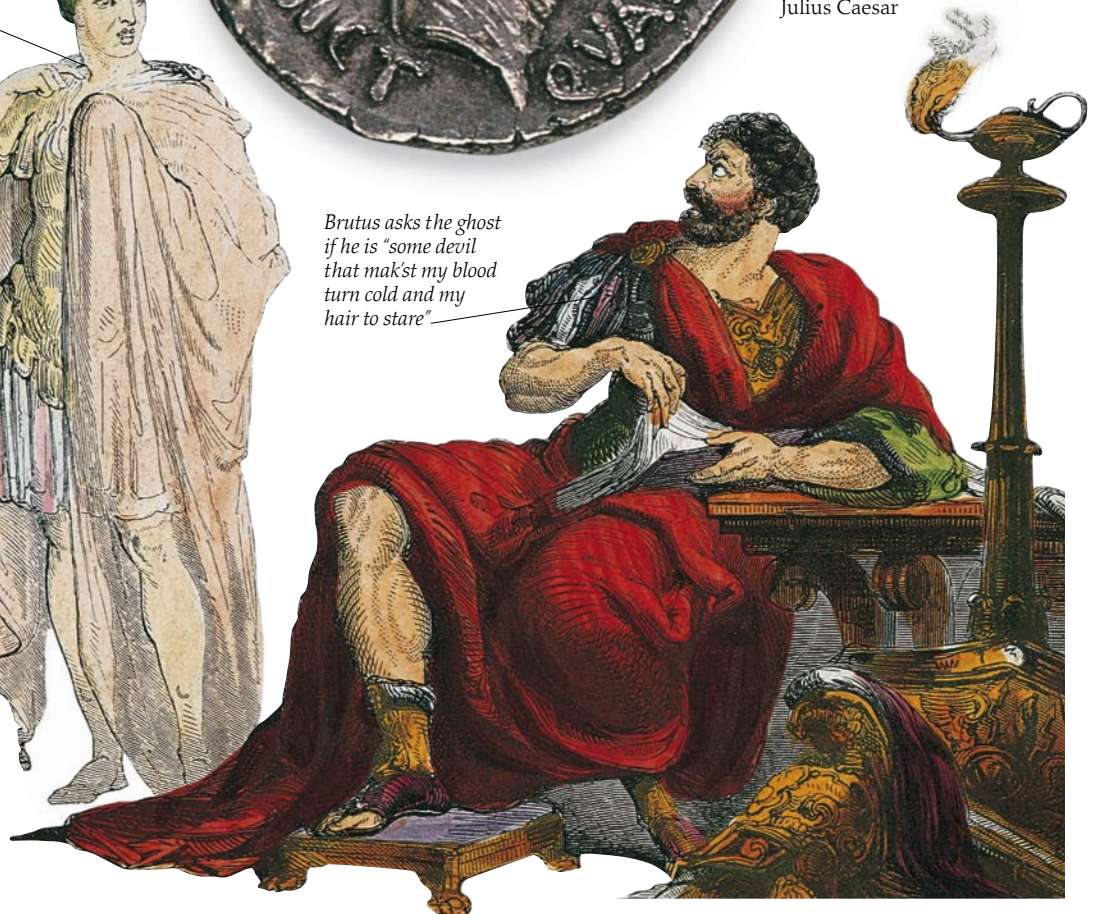


Brutus asks the ghost if he is "some devil that mak'st my blood turn cold and my hair to stare"



Roman coin with the portrait of Julius Caesar

OFFENDING PORTRAIT
Julius Caesar (100–44 BC) was the subject of Shakespeare's first play about Roman history. Caesar was an ambitious and successful Roman general and politician, who was eventually murdered because he started to act like a king. He was the first Roman to put his portrait on a coin, which offended many people. Previously, only dead Romans had been given this honor.



MURDERING HERO

The hero of Shakespeare's play *Julius Caesar* is not Caesar but his friend and killer Brutus. Brutus fears that Caesar wants to become king, and decides he must die so that Rome can remain free. However, the murder plunges the state into civil war. Mark Antony rouses the people of Rome against the killers with his famous speech, "Friends, Romans, countrymen, lend me your ears."